The RDA for a preschool child (1-6 years) is given in Table 3.1

Table 3.1 ICMR recommended dietary allowances for pre-school children

Nutrient	Years	
	1-3	4-6
Weight (Kg)	12.9	18.0
Energy (kcal)	1060	1350
Protein (g)	16.7	20.1
Fat (g)	27	25
Calcium (mg)	600	600
Iron (mg)	9	13
Vitamin A (µg)	400	400
Beta carotene (µg)	3200	3200
Thiamine (mg)	0.5	0.7
Riboflavin (mg)	0.6	0.8
Nicotinic acid (mg)	8	11
Pyridoxine (mg)	0.9	0.9
Ascorbic acid (mg)	40	40
Folic acid (µg)	150	150
Vitamin B12(µg)	0.2 to 1	0.2 to 1

Source: Dietary Guidelines for Indians - A Manual by Kamala Krishnaswamy, B. Sesikeran (Second Edition 2011), NIN, ICMR

Energy

The energy requirements of toddlers and children vary greatly based on differences in growth rate and level of physical activity. Insufficient food intake during this stage will not only result in under nutrition in terms of inadequate weight gain but will also hinder growth.

Protein

Protein is the primary component in many body tissues. Proteins build, maintain and restore tissues in the body such as muscles and organs. As a child grows and develops, protein is a crucial nutrient needed to provide optimal growth. Protein intake should be 1.5 to 2 g/kg body weight.

Fat

Until the age of three years, dietary fat plays a role in brain development. Fat comprises approximately 60% of the central and peripheral nervous system that essentially control, regulate and integrate every body system; thus it is essential that growing toddlers obtain adequate fat from their diet. A diet consisting of 30% of total calories from fat will help the child to meet their daily calorie and nutrient requirements for growth.

Vitamins

Vitamin A is essential to support rapid growth and to help combat infections. Inadequate intakes of vitamin A may lead to vitamin A deficiency which can cause visual impairment in the form of night blindness and may increase the risk of illness and death from childhood infections, including measles and those causing diarrhea. Milk,eggs, carrots and green leafy vegetables should be included in the diet of the child. Vitamin C is important for the child's general health and immune system. It can also help their body absorb iron. Good sources of vitamin C include oranges, kiwi fruit, strawberries and tomatoes.

Minerals

Calcium is the principle mineral required by the body for the process of bone mineralization. Toddlers and young children have an increased need for calcium to promote the rapid bone growth and skeletal development that takes place during these early years of life. Around 600 mg of calcium per day is required during this age. Milk is the best source of calcium. Hence the diet of a preschool child should include 1-2 glasses of milk per day.

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